

WORLD-CLASS EXPERIENCE
Travellers aboard the Delhi-Bhopal Vande Bharat Express

an overnight journey that would take about 11 hours," she says. "Vande Bharat, however, departs early in the morning and we're in Katra by afternoon. We save an extra night."

Beyond speed, Maansi appreciates the plush interiors, comfortable rotatable seats and the immaculate toilets. To her, Vande Bharat compares favourably with the best of superfast trains abroad. "I actually prefer it over flying," she adds with a smile. "And the chai they serve...just perfect." ■

speed, comfort and convenience.

Beyond speed, Vande Bharat offers a passenger-centric design with plush, comfortable seating akin to international standards, modular toilets and automatic doors. Railway minister Ashwini Vaishnaw frequently shares video clips demonstrating the train's performance, like the one that shows a glass of water filled to the brim remaining undisturbed while the train speeds at its peak. As of December 2024, Indian Railways operates 136 Vande Bharat trains across the nation, linking major cities and reducing rail journey times by 25-45 per cent. In just under five years, millions of passengers have embraced this cutting-edge innovation, with occupancy rates exceeding 100 per cent across all routes. This shows that passengers are willing to pay up to 50 per cent higher fares for the enhanced comfort and punctuality the train offers. Even more revealing, internal assessments indicate that the Vande Bharat is luring travellers away from airlines, leading to a 20 per cent reduction in air traffic on certain routes.

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Indian Railways is now preparing to launch a sleeper version of the Vande Bharat to transform overnight journeys, promising to cut travel times on long-haul routes like Delhi-Mumbai from 16 hours to 12, offering a faster alternative without sacrificing comfort. The Vande Bharat isn't limited by terrain either. Soon, a specially engineered eight-coach version will make its way into the Kashmir Valley, built to endure extreme weather conditions and heavy snowfall. As Sudhanshu Mani, the former general manager of ICF who led the Vande Bharat project, aptly puts it, "The Vande Bharat project has enabled India to dream bigger and design and manufacture a bullet train in the future." In that sense, it is a worthy successor to the Shatabdi and a perfect precursor to bullet trains. ■